Welcome to the LVNA

Villager

The Newsletter of the Lakewood Village Neighborhood Association

December 2010 Volume 54 Number 12 Sunnyvale, California Editor: Phyllis Fowler

LVNA Parade is December 4th at 11:00 am

and bring a toy for the Toy For Tots bin at the Parade end!

No Meeting in December, Next Meeting January 12, 2011

President's Column

-Fred Fowler



It's Parade Time!

The days are chilly again, the leaves are turning colors and the noonday sun stands low in the sky. We all know what that means. It's Parade Time in Lakewood Village!

Come one, come all on Saturday, December 4th to watch the latest edition of the **Lakewood Village Holiday Parade** wind its way through our neighborhood streets. The **Lakewood Elementary School Color** Guard will lead it off at 11:00am from the corner of Lakechime and Meadowlake in front of Lakewood School. They will be followed by the combined forces of the **Fremont High School and Columbia Middle School marching Bands**, a big bunch of awesome classic cars, an antique 1930's garbage truck, a fire engine, police cars, and of course the big man himself, Santa Claus. There will be lots of marchers of all kinds, from celebrities to school kids, all proudly strutting their stuff for the community. At the end of the parade (in the Fairwood Park picnic area) there will be the usual reception where everyone can enjoy some hot cocoa and cookies and the fellowship of living in the best neighborhood in Sunnyvale. You won't want to miss it!

Last year we estimated that about 4,000 people either watched the parade from the street or attended the reception or both. This year we expect the turnout to be even larger. Times were hard this time last year, and they aren't much better now. We needed the parade then and we need it now to give us a respite from all of the bad economic news we've been hearing. We need to be reminded that even though times are tough, we've all seen tough times before and if we work together *(Continued page 3)*

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Holiday Lighting Contest

By Fred Fowler



Greetings neighbors. It is December again, and as is customary for this time of year we will have no LVNA general meeting this month. Our parade and the holidays will keep us all busy enough without getting together on the 2nd Wednesday. Best holiday wishes to all!

There is another important event coming up though – the **LVNA Lighting Contest!** Part of our holiday tradition is to recognize the hard work, creativity and inspiration of Lakewood residents who decorate their houses at this time of year. Some of those houses are a sight to behold! As I've said before, no neighborhood in Sunnyvale lights up the way we do, and people come from as far away as Morgan Hill and San Francisco to enjoy the lights and marvel at the spectacle. It is another tradition that makes Lakewood Village a special place to live. *(continued on page 2)*

More Arson Along the John Christian Greenbelt

by Fred Fowler

The LVNA was very lucky to have Sunnyvale Public Safety **Chief Don Johnson** visit us during the last LVNA General Meeting on November 10th. Chief Don came and reported to us that while the budget for the Public Safety department is being reduced, the safety of the city is not being hurt and that the department is still quite effective at catching criminals. One example he gave of the department's efficiency is the fact that they recently apprehended an arsonist who had set several fires along the John Christian Greenbelt. Readers of ***The Villager*** will recall that I ran across one of those fires myself this past summer and called it in to the Public Safety department. At the time I wrote that the best thing we as Lakewood Village residents could do is stay vigilant and report any suspicious activity to the police. There are more than 3,500 pairs of eyes between the 3,500 residents of Lakewood Village, and *(Continued on page 5)*

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Holiday Lighting Contest

(continued from page 1)



The rules of the contest are simple. Get your creative juices flowing and show us all what you can do! Decorations can be hand-made or store bought. They can be small and modest or huge and spectacular. It doesn't matter. All that is important is that they are expressive and sincere. They need to convey the spirit of the neighborhood and of this special time of year. Many people in Lakewood Village have taken up this challenge in past years and produced memorable results. I expect this year's entries to be even better than before.

The LVNA always arranges for a celebrity judge to pick the winners in the contest. The neighborhood is divided into four pieces, separated east-west by Lawrence Expressway and north-south by Lakehaven/Sandia avenue. On a specified night the judge is escorted through the neighborhood by some LVNA officials and the winner of each section is chosen. There is also a "grand champion" selected for the entire neighborhood as a whole.

The results are published in the January newsletter.

We haven't identified the "celebrity judge" as of yet, but the date of the judging has been set. To be eligible to participate, your decorations must be powered on and available for review on the evening of Sunday, December 19th. Judging will take place on that night only, rain or shine. If you want to take part in the competition, be sure to be ready!

The Lighting Contest marks the last event of the LVNA year. Things start off in March with the election of new officers, move on to July when Dumpster Day takes place, proceed to September and the LVNA Picnic, and end up in December with both the Holiday Parade and Lighting competition. When the contest is over the LVNA will "hunker down" for the rest of the winter, waiting for spring to start the cycle Hopefully it will continue this way for many years to come

To those of you who are about to start decorating, I would like to say "thank you very much!" Your efforts help give Lakewood Village both a "personality" and a "soul" that is not very common among communities in Silicon Valley. All of our lives are richer because of the community we live in, and our community is nothing more than a bunch of ordinary people who occasionally get together to do things for the benefit of all.

A philosopher once said "it is better to light one small candle than to curse the darkness". We go one better. We light up a whole neighborhood! Thanks for doing so, and may the most creative decorations win! ◆

Thoughts on Thanksgiving

Thanksgiving dinners take eighteen hours to prepare. They are consumed in twelve minutes. Half-times take twelve minutes. This is not coincidence.

What we're really talking about is a wonderful day set aside on the fourth Thursday of November when no one diets. I mean, why else would they call it Thanksgiving? *~Erma Bombeck, "No One Diets on Thanksgiving," 11/26/81*



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It's Parade Time!

(Continued from page 1) we can make good thing happen no matter what else is going on in the world.

The Lakewood Village Holiday Parade has been lifting spirits for more than 30 years now. Some of the organizers of the parade this year remember enjoying the parade when they were children themselves. It has always been a purely volunteer effort, put together by our neighbors for the sake of our children and our community. I hope it will always be that way.

We all have a part to play in this neighborhood tradition. If you are one of the organizers, thank you very much for what you have done! If you are not one of the direct volunteers, then make sure you get out of the house on December 4th and cheer the parade on! No one is getting paid to make the parade happen. The organizers and participants are all doing their work for nothing more than a "thank you". Let's be sure to say that "thank you" when we have that chance. As the parade is passing by, be sure to be there and shout out your "thank you" to the ones who are making it happen.

It should be another day to remember! I'll see you there. ◆

Thoughts on Winter

Winter is the season in which people try to keep the house as warm as it was in the summer, when they complained about the heat. *~Author Unknown*

One kind word can warm three winter months.
~Japanese Proverb

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PIQE Graduation at Fairwood School

By Phyllis Fowler

On November 17th, I attended a Commencement Ceremony at Fairwood school. There was a great deal of anticipation. The room was filled with parents and children who watched with excitement as the graduates walked up to the front of the audience to receive their certificates. The pride was evident on everyone's faces. For many, it was their first commencement of any kind. However, the ceremony wasn't for the children. Instead they were watching their mothers and fathers graduating.

This parents had just completed a nine-week course presented by PIQE, the Parent Institute for Quality Education. The course is designed to empower parents to take an active role in their children's education. The program is a partnership between San Jose State and local elementary, middle and high schools. The PIQE's mission is to connect parents, schools and community as partners to advance the education of every child.

The ceremony was conducted by Ms Lorena Lechuga Cholula, the Interim Director of PIQE for the San Jose region. Guest speakers were Martha Molina, Fairwood's Principal Sarah Tellez and Sunnyvale School Board Member Phyllis Fowler. The ceremony was translated in both English and Spanish, no one felt left out.

Ms. Lechuga said that PIQE has been taught at Columbia Middle School and Vargas Elementary *(Continued page 7)*

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A Rocky Start For The New Villager

by Fred Fowler

Hello folks. As I reported in the last edition of *The Villager*, we are now using our own LVNA equipment to print and fold the newsletter, saving us money and letting us expand the size of the publication. We even have the capability to print things in color! I wrote a long article in the November *Villager* where I explained all of the new capabilities and asked you to check out the color pictures and advertisements that were now part of the publication.

Of course, I wrote the article before we had printed anything with the new equipment. As it turned out, the first issue we produced had some "issues" that we had to scramble to overcome. One of the ironic things that happened was that some of you received a newsletter that wasn't printed in color at all! Not only that, but the newsletter itself was delivered very late. Clearly, things didn't go as planned.

The story of the first expanded issue of *The Villager* is a story of "problems overcome" and "lessons learned". There were several surprises (and catastrophes) that almost derailed things altogether. In the end everything worked out and all 1,700 issues were printed and delivered. I don't mind telling you, though, that the first edition was an ordeal for Phyllis and I. We had a heck of a time with it. Luckily we now know what to expect and the next run of *The Villager* should go much more smoothly.

THE FIRST SURPRISE

The first surprise we got was discovering that the printer arrived with no toner cartridges in it. Phyllis and I unpacked the printer and set it up the Wednesday before the newsletter was to be distributed. I went to print some test pages, and nothing came out! Phyllis checked online and found some cartridges we could afford, and had them shipped overnight to us. They arrived Friday afternoon. On Friday evening I loaded the cartridges and printed a few pages successfully. Everything seemed ready for the next day.

DUSTY FLUFF

Phyllis and I had just finished our breakfast on Saturday morning when catastrophe struck. I went to print the first copy of *The Villager*, but when I powered on the printer it didn't come up. It started its initialization process, but after a few moments a red light began to flash and it displayed a cryptic error code in its LCD window. The code was 'CK,59", and no matter how many times I powered the printer off and then on again it still ended up with the flashing red light and this error code. What could I do?

The situation seemed pretty grim. The LVNA had bought the refurbished printer from an online company based in Canada. The customer service phone number had a recording that told me to call back on Monday. That wasn't an option because the newsletter had to be distributed that weekend. It was Saturday morning. Where could I get help?

Luckily, using Google I was able to get assistance. With it I got a list of HP printer service technicians in Silicon Valley. One of them turned out to be in Sunnyvale. I called the listed number and a man answered. He agreed to come to our house (on a Saturday) to see what he could do. I could hardly believe how lucky it was to find a person with the right skills who was also willing to make a house call on a weekend to help us out.

The technician arrived at about 3:30pm, and we both got to work. By 5:00pm we had found the trouble. A big ball of dusty fluff has fallen into one of the many optical sensors in the machine and blocked it. All we had to do was pull the dust ball out and the printer began to work normally again.

By 5:30pm the printer was put back together and the technician properly paid and thanked and sent on his way. Phyllis and I then set about running the first color copy of *The Villager* through the printer. It came out beautifully! We kept it as a memento of the *(Continued on Page 6)*

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More Arson

(Continued from page 1) we can keep watch over our neighborhood better than anyone else can. The police can find and arrest criminals, but they can do it much quicker if we see the criminals in action and tell the police who to look for.

Is this kind of vigilance still necessary now that the arsonist has been "caught?" The facts speak for themselves. Chief Don came to talk to us on Wednesday night, and on the following Saturday night there were MULTIPLE fires set in the brush along the Greenbelt. Someone had walked down the path and set fires as he/she went. It is unclear whether the culprit is the same one who set the summer fires or a different person altogether. All that is clear is that the threat of arson along the John Christian Greenbelt is far from over.

I heard about the fires when a neighbor who lives near the Greenbelt came to see me the following morning. He was (understandably) quite upset and worried about what to do. I suggested that he get some of his neighbors together to form a neighborhood watch group.



I promised that if he formed the group, I would go to the first meeting and bring Sunnyvale Neighborhood Resource Officer Jim Davis with me. I talked with the neighbor about the possibility of mounting inexpensive hidden "Web Cam" cameras in his backyard foliage in order to keep an electronic watch on things. In the end, there were many things that he could do to help protect his home from fires set by capricious and irresponsible people.

During the talk that Chief Don gave us, I asked him to pretend he had a "magic wand" he could wave to create the perfect Public Safety department he wanted. I asked him what that department would be like. He then answered that he wouldn't change anything about how the city is currently patrolled, or about how the fire stations are staffed. He said what he would change is to greatly increase the staff he has who are dedicated to crime prevention and youth outreach. He has enough officers to respond to the crimes that take place at the moment. The ongoing budget cuts that have been made over the years have cut back the department's ability to head off the causes of future crimes. Chief Don has the resources to respond to crimes after they happen. My impression of his answer is that he doesn't think he has enough resources to prevent those crimes in the first place. If he is right, we'll be facing more crimes in the future like the Greenbelt arson, rather than less.

What can we do? The answer is still the same as it was last summer. We as a community have a great deal of power to keep our neighborhood safe. That power comes from our numbers and our watchfulness. The police can't be everywhere in our neighborhood at once. If we work together, though, we CAN be everywhere at once. Together we can see what is going on. We can tell the police what is happening and help them get it taken care of.

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I'll make the same promise to all of you that I made to our neighbor living near the John Christian Greenbelt. If you get a meeting of your neighbors together to organize a watch group, I'll attend the meeting and bring a police officer with me. Together we'll learn how to watch efficiently and communicate with the police effectively. If we do then we'll be taking the safety and security of our neighborhood into our own hands.

Lakewood Village has done this kind of thing before. In the 1990's we were plagued with incessant graffiti, and the neighborhood organized to fight it. It took years of effort, and a good deal of self sacrifice, but in the end, we won. I like walking by the side and back of the Lakewood Shopping Center and looking at those broad white walls with no tags on them at all! Back in the 90s most of us would have thought that would have been impossible. The fact that the walls are clean now speaks to the power we have as a community. We can stop crime if we convince the criminals that we will not tolerate it. We can get others to respect our neighborhood if we show them how much we respect it ourselves

When the graffiti stopped in the neighborhood, some of the local kids told us it was because they finally realized that someone cared. The same will probably be true for the other types of crime we're experiencing. If the miscreants realize that we as a neighborhood actually care enough to do something about it, they will go elsewhere. It worked before. It can work again.

Let's give it a try. ◆

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A Rocky Start *(Continued from page 4)*

occasion. One down, 1,699 to go!

17 HOURS

Phyllis and I had to feel our way through the printing and folding process until we got a routine established. The printing process is a bit tricky because we had to print 8.5 x 11 inch pages side by side on 11 x 17 inch sheets in such a way that the folded result would have the right pages in the right places. We finally ended up printing the sheets in batches of 50, then folding that set together while the next 50 were printing. With all of the printing and flipping, it took about 30 minutes to produce 50 newsletters.

1,700 newsletter copies would take at least 17 hours to produce. Phyllis and I had to get busy immediately, as we were starting that 17 hour run at 5:30pm on Saturday evening.

We ordered out for dinner (from our new newsletter advertiser, Shanghai Restaurant) and got to work. We didn't stop until 2:00am when we finally were exhausted and went to bed. We had produced 750 newsletters that evening. We were hoping we could get the rest of them printed and folded the next day.

COLOR SATURATION

While we were printing the newsletters on Saturday night, there were some ominous indications on the printer that things might still be going wrong. The toner cartridges that Phyllis and I had bought were "HP compatible" off-brand ones, and the printer manual warned that if we used non-HP cartridges then the "toner remaining" meter on the printer would not be accurate. The cartridges were rated at "12,000 pages at 5% coverage", so I expected to get through the entire run of the newsletter on a single black cartridge with at least 75% of each color cartridge to spare.

By 2:00am we had another crisis. That's when the black toner cartridge ran out completely!

We had used up an entire black cartridge and most of the color cartridges and we were less than halfway through the run! We went to bed and I had nightmares about what to do the next day.

The next morning I read through the manual again, looking for some clue as to what to do. I found a *(Cont. next page)*

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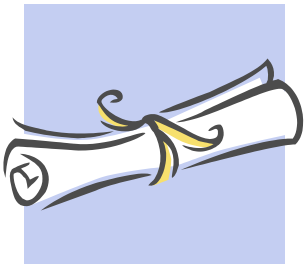
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PIQE Graduation (Continued from Page 3)

School, but this is the first time the program has been taught at Fairwood. She told me that after 23 years of the program in California, they're starting to hear the powerful stories of success from children of PIQE graduates.

The 27 graduates for the first class are:

Ezequiel Alcazar
Jeniffer C. Alvardo
Hilda Alvarez
Anna Rubi Fonseca
Maria D. Garcia
Horacio Gomez
Salustria Gomez
Omar P. Guzman
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Rose Marie Wolhar
Matt Philip Wolhar
Martin Aguilar"



Ms. Cholula said, "I hope to hear 10-15 years from now the great success stories of your graduates." These proud parents (and graduates!) are looking at a brighter future for their children (and so am I)

On the back of the program was this story that I wanted to share with everyone called *Unity.*

I dreamed I was in a shop and saw two sculptors working. The clay they used was the mind of a child. One was a teacher, his tools were books, music, and art. The other one, a father, worked with a skillful hand and his heart was filled with sweetness and love. Day after day the teacher labored with his sure and skillful hand while the father labored at his side as he polished and smoothed. And at the end of their labor, they felt proud of what they had created, because what they had formed in the child could not be sold nor purchased. And both agreed that if they would worked one without the other, they would have failed because behind the teacher was the school and behind the father, the home.◆



A Rocky Start cont.

set of instructions for setting the "color saturation" for each of the four sets of toner. When I checked the settings that the printer had arrived with, I found that they were all set at the "top quality" mark. The printed results had been beautiful so far, but the printer had been set to use toner very generously in order to achieve those results.

In the end, Phyllis and I experimented a bit and found that the quality of the printed results were quite acceptable when the "color saturation" settings were set to the lowest possible mark. When we did so, the use of toner went down dramatically. We used up a full black cartridge and 70% of the color cartridges on the first 750 newsletter copies. We used less than half of our 2nd black cartridge printing the other 950 newsletters, and we almost made it through the 2nd half run on the 30% of the color cartridges that remained. Using the low saturation settings, it should be no problem to make the cartridges last as long as we originally expected they would.

LATE DELIVERY

While Phyllis and I were struggling with the printer, the newsletter walkers were wondering what was going on. They normally get their newsletters on the Saturday before the LVNA meeting, but Phyllis and I didn't even start producing the newsletters until Saturday at 5:30pm. When we had put together enough copies for one side of the neighborhood we delivered them at about 11:00am on Sunday morning. We (Continued on page 8)

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Editor	-	Phyllis Fowler	(408) 747-1454

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A Rocky Start (cont. from page 7)

worked and worked all day and delivered almost all of the ones for the other side at about 6:00pm on Sunday evening. I printed and folded the remaining 250 newsletters on Monday night and delivered them to the walker coordinator on Tuesday morning. I walked my own newsletter route (110 homes) on Tuesday evening. It was all done barely in time for the LVNA meeting the following day.



LESSONS LEARNED

And so the first edition of *The Villager* that was produced on LVNA printing equipment has passed into history. It was an experience that I will not forget any time soon. Lots and lots of things went wrong, and I hope that Phyllis and I never have to go through a similar ordeal in the future.

As bad as the production process was, though, there are still a great many good things that have come out of it. The finished product was just beautiful! The extra space is serving its purpose in providing more room for neighborhood news, and our advertisers are anxious to convert their advertisements to color (and pay us extra for printing them that way!) All in all, as bad as the printing process was, the overall idea looks like it is a success.

The first run of the new *Villager* was definitely one to remember. Like all "birth" experiences, it was painful and messy. I'm sure we'll have more problems as we go through the "terrible twos" and other growing pains. After a while, though, the process will learn how to stand on its own and grow. Before long this "child" will be something we can all point to with pride. It will be a neighborhood resource that will pay many dividends in the years to come. We've seen the first step. The rest of the journey will be exciting indeed. ◆

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To submit articles or advertisements for publication, please contact the editor:

Phyllis Fowler at (408)747-1454 or email: phyllis@fmfa.com